



TRANSLATION TEAM · PROFESSIONAL CLUB

Translation Handbook

A Practical Guide to Arabic–English Translation

دليل الترجمة

مرشد عملي للترجمة بين العربية والإنجليزية

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ANALYSE · TRANSLATE · COMMENT

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● ● ● START HERE

How to use this handbook

كيف تستخدم هذا الدليل

This is a **field handbook**: keep it next to your laptop while you translate. It follows the order in which a translator actually works. Part I covers what to do *before* translating. Parts II and III cover the *decisions* you make while translating. Parts IV and V cover how to *analyse, justify and check* your work. Part VI is for practice.

1 · Analyse

حلّل

Client, purpose, audience, genre, terms, problems. *Ch. 2, 14, 17*

2 · Translate

ترجم

Choose an equivalent, a strategy or a procedure for each problem. *Ch. 5–13*

3 · Comment

علق

Justify, revise, and assess the risks. *Ch. 15, 16, 20*

The page elements

CONCEPT

A definition, with the Arabic term beside it. Key concepts are also listed in the Glossary.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Practical advice drawn from professional practice.

COMMON ERROR

A frequent mistake, and how to avoid it.

EXAMPLE

A source text and its target text, side by side, with the strategy used and the reason for it.

KEY TAKEAWAY

The one thing to remember from a section.

CHECKLIST

Steps to tick off while you work, collected on p. 38.

Where the content comes from

Each chapter opens with tags that show where its content comes from. This keeps what the team supplied separate from what was added to complete the framework.

Team notes

Drawn from the Translation Team's own course notes and drafts. These were consolidated, corrected and edited.

Added framework

Added to meet the handbook brief (for example, extra strategies, the seven procedures, Fairclough, terminology, AI/MT). Every addition is cited.

Verify

Needs checking against its original source before the final print run. The same flag appears as **verify** in the text.

Abbreviations

SL / TL	source / target language	اللغة المصدر / الهدف	MT / NMT	machine / neural machine translation
ST / TT	source / target text	النص المصدر / الهدف	LLM	large language model
SLC / TLC	source / target-language culture		PE	post-editing
TS	Translation Studies	علم الترجمة	CAT	computer-assisted translation
MSA	Modern Standard Arabic		CDA	critical discourse analysis

PART I · BEFORE YOU TRANSLATE

01

The translator's foundation

أسس الترجمة والمترجم

Team notes

CONCEPT

Translation الترجمة التحريريةTransferring the **meaning** of a written text from one language into another.**Interpretation** الترجمة الشفهيةTransferring **spoken** language into another language orally.**Communication** التواصلTo understand and to be understood. Translation is communication **between two languages**.

Four ways to think about translation

1 • Transfer of meaning

We carry the meaning across, not the words.

2 • Communication

If the reader does not understand, the translation has failed.

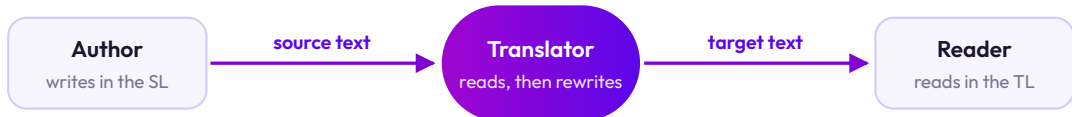
3 • A search for equivalence

We look for the TL expression that matches the SL one (Ch. 5).

4 • Approximation

No two languages match exactly, so we get *as close as possible* (Ch. 10).

Where the translator stands



"Noise" = anything that blocks the message: cultural gaps, ambiguity, errors

Two kinds of translator

Commissioned (بتكليف): a client asks you to translate, so you follow the client's policy and style.**Self-initiated** (بمبادرة ذاتية): no client. You choose the text yourself, such as a poem you love, and answer for your own choices.**Note:** a **freelancer** is self-employed but still works for clients, so a freelancer is a *commissioned* translator.

What a good translator needs

- Two languages: **bilingual**
- Two cultures: **bicultural**
- Wide general knowledge, like a "walking encyclopedia"
- A rich vocabulary (الحصيلة اللغوية)
- Practice, and the habit of revising

KEY TAKEAWAY

A translator translates **meaning** for a **reader**, never just words.

PART I · BEFORE YOU TRANSLATE

02

Translation preparation

نصائح وتقنيات وإعداد للترجمة

Team notes

Added: the translation brief (Nord 1997)

Before you translate a single word, answer three questions. Together they make up your **translation brief** (موجز الترجمة).

Who is the client?

من هو العميل؟

Who asked for the translation?
What style and policy do they follow?

What is the purpose?

ما الغرض التواصل؟

Is the text meant to inform,
persuade, instruct or entertain?

Who is the audience?

من هو الجمهور المستهدف؟

Experts or the general public?
Adults or children?

Six preparation steps

- 1 Read the whole text twice.
- 2 Break it down into paragraphs, then sentences, then phrases.
- 3 Highlight difficult words, idioms and names.
- 4 Research the topic.
- 5 Make a word list of key terms (Ch. 13).
- 6 Picture a first draft in your mind.

Five golden habits

- Be faithful (الأمانة) to the meaning.
- Aim for a translation that is **accurate, faithful and acceptable**.
- Translation is **rewriting**. It must read naturally.
- **Always revise**, even your best work.
- Translate **everything**, including titles and captions.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Translation is like a minefield (الترجمة حقل ألغام). One wrong word can cause real harm. **If you are not sure, check. Never guess.**

A brief in action

EXAMPLE

Text	A short news report about Kuwait and Australia
Client	KUNA (Kuwait News Agency). Follow its house style and approved names.
Purpose	To inform. Keep the language clear, formal and neutral.
Audience	English readers interested in Kuwait and the Middle East
So...	Use formal register, no short forms, and keep the headline short with nothing added.

COMMON ERROR

Starting to translate before reading the whole text. You then miss the main idea and the words that keep coming back.

PART I · BEFORE YOU TRANSLATE

03 Arabic vs. English

مقارنة بين العربية والإنجليزية

Team notes

CONCEPT

Verbal sentence الجملة الفعلية A sentence that starts with a verb. Formal Arabic prefers it: verb – subject – object (VSO).

Register المستوى اللغوي How formal or informal the language is.

The main differences

	English	Arabic
Word order	Subject first: <i>Sam ate the cake.</i>	Verb first: أكلَ سامُ الكعكةَ
Sentences	Short, with full stops	Long, joined with <i>و، ف، ثمَّ</i>
The verb “is”	Always written	Often dropped, or rendered يُعدّ
Synonyms	One word is enough	Pairs add emphasis: شجاعٌ مغوارٌ

Small words, big traps EN → AR

English	Arabic	Why
<i>He is in bed.</i>	إنه نائمٌ	It means “asleep”, not في السرير
<i>As an officer, I...</i>	بصفتي ضابطاً...	Here <i>as</i> means a role, not ك
<i>Translation is a fascinating field.</i>	تُعدّ الترجمة مجالاً شائقاً	Start with a verb
<i>...to see the Roman ruins</i>	لزيارة الآثار الرومانية	Arabic says “visit”

The other direction AR → EN

SOURCE

هو شجاعٌ مغوارٌ.

TARGET

He is very brave.

Why: Arabic uses two synonyms for emphasis. English does not, so **X brave and daring** sounds odd. One strong word is enough.

Punctuation: Arabic uses its own marks ؟ ، ، . Never leave an English comma or question mark in an Arabic text.

Which Arabic? Use **Modern Standard Arabic** (الفصحى المعاصرة) for written translation. Use a dialect (العامية) only if the client asks for it.

KEY TAKEAWAY

English → Arabic: put the verb first and join short sentences.

Arabic → English: put the subject first, drop repeated synonyms and split long sentences.

Linking words

EN → AR

Added: translator's toolkit

Arabic joins ideas more than English does, so good linking words make an Arabic translation flow.

English	Arabic	English	Arabic
<i>however</i>	غير أنّ / إلا أنّ	<i>moreover</i>	علاوةً على ذلك
<i>in addition</i>	بالإضافة إلى ذلك	<i>therefore</i>	لذلك / ولذا
<i>as a result</i>	ونتيجةً لذلك	<i>on the other hand</i>	من ناحيةٍ أخرى
<i>for example</i>	على سبيل المثال	<i>in other words</i>	بعبارةٍ أخرى
<i>although</i>	على الرغم من أنّ	<i>finally</i>	وأخيراً / وفي الختام

Punctuation

Mark	English	Arabic	Note
Comma	,	،	Arabic uses more commas
Semicolon	;	؛	It often links a cause and its result
Question mark	?	؟	The Arabic mark is reversed
Quotation marks	“ ”	« »	Both forms are common in Arabic
Capital letters	Yes	No	Make names clear in other ways

Numbers and dates

Digits. Arabic texts use either 1 2 3 or ١ ٢ ٣.
Follow the client, and do not mix the two.

Dates. 21 March 2026 → 21 مارس 2026 in the Gulf, or 2026 آذار 21 in the Levant. Say whether a date is Hijri or Gregorian.

Numbers 3–10 reverse the gender of the noun:

ثلاثة طلاب (masculine noun, feminine number)

ثلاث طالبات (feminine noun, masculine number)

COMMON ERROR

Leaving English punctuation in an Arabic text: نعم، شكراً؟ → نعم، شكراً؟ X

PART I · BEFORE YOU TRANSLATE

04

Meaning, form and context

المعنى والبناء والسياق

Team notes

CONCEPT

- Form** البناء The structure of the words: word, phrase, sentence.
- Meaning** المعنى The idea those words express.
- Denotation** المعنى المعجمي The basic dictionary meaning.
- Connotation** المعنى الإيحائي The extra feeling a word carries: positive, negative, respectful.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Meaning comes before form. المعنى أهم من البناء You may change the structure, but never the meaning.

SOURCE

Blair, Bush's poodle

TARGET

بلير، تابع بوش

Why: "poodle" means nothing political in Arabic. We keep the meaning, "an obedient follower", and drop the image.

Same meaning, different feeling

die	مات neutral
pass away	توفي respectful
kill · assassinate	اغتيال · قتل political
friend · comrade	رفيق · صديق party member

What is really meant?

Sometimes the speaker means more than the words say.

أشعر بالحر. → "Please turn on the AC."

It's freezing in here. → "Close the window."

Context decides

لكل مقام مقال



Micro context: the words around the problem.

Macro context: who wrote it, for whom, when and where. The translator sits in the middle.

Context also tells you which meaning a word has when it has several (see the next page).

Words with more than one meaning

CONCEPT

Homonymy المشترك اللفظي One word with several **unrelated** meanings.

Polysemy تعدد المعنى One word with several **related** meanings.

HOMONYMY: UNRELATED MEANINGS

bank	ضفة النهر · مصرف
case	a container · علبة · a legal matter قضية
عين	an eye · a water spring · a spy

POLYSEMY: RELATED MEANINGS

بناء	a building · a structure
تطهير	purifying from sin · disinfecting a wound
احتجاز	retaining water · holding hostages

SOURCE

The patient's **case** was discussed at the meeting.

TARGET

نوقشت حالة المريض في الاجتماع.

Why: the words *patient* and *meeting* show that *case* means a medical حالة, not a container or a court case.

More words with different feelings

Neutral word	Words with a feeling
horse حصان	<i>steed</i> جواد (noble, positive) · <i>nag</i> (old or weak, negative)
die مات	<i>استشهد</i> (religious or political, positive) · <i>نفق</i> (used of animals; insulting if used of people)
thin نحيف	<i>slim</i> رشيق (positive) · <i>skinny</i> هزيل (negative)

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

When a word has several meanings, **read the sentence around it** (the micro context), then the whole text (the macro context). Never choose the first meaning in the dictionary.

Try it: which meaning?

1 She sat on the **bank** and watched the boats.

2 زرعت الشركة عيناً في مكتب منافسها.

3 The lawyer won the **case**.

Answers: 1. 2. 3. a spy · a water spring · a water spring

KEY TAKEAWAY

The right meaning is the one that fits the **context**. لكلّ مقام مقال

PART II · DECISION-MAKING

05

Equivalence

التكافؤ

Team notes

Verify: source of the three-type model (likely Farghal & Shunnaq 1999)

CONCEPT

Equivalence التكافؤ A central idea in Translation Studies: finding the TL expression that **matches** the SL one.

Formal الشكلي Keeps the **form** of the SL: the same structure, word class and image.

Functional الوظيفي Keeps the **function** by using a TL expression that does the same job.

Ideational الفكري Keeps only the **basic idea**, in plain words.

One sentence, three equivalents

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then.

CLOSE TO THE SOURCE FORM

A · Formal

ظَلَّتْ الاتفاقية حُرُفًا مَيِّتًا
منذ ذلك الحين

same image; unclear to readers

B · Functional ✓

ظَلَّتْ الاتفاقية حَبْرًا عَلَى وَرَقٍ
منذ ذلك الحين

an Arabic idiom, same job

C · Ideational

لَمْ تُطَبَّقِ الاتفاقية
منذ ذلك الحين

plain meaning, no image

More examples

Source	Formal	Functional	Ideational
<i>Ali is second to none in poetry.</i>	علي ثانٍ لا أحد ×	علي لا يُشَقُّ له غبار في الشعر	علي شاعرٌ متميزٌ
<i>Think outside the box.</i>	فكّر خارج الصندوق	فكّر بطريقة إبداعية	

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Formal equivalence is not always wrong. فكّر خارج الصندوق is now common in Arabic, and legal texts often stay close to the form. Choose the option your reader will understand.

COMMON ERROR

Mixing up terms: *agreement* is اتفاقية, but *treaty* is معاهدة.

KEY TAKEAWAY

When the form does not work, keep the **function**. If no idiom fits, keep the **idea**.

PART II · DECISION-MAKING

06

Collocation, idiomaticity and phraseology

التلازم اللفظي والتعابير الاصطلاحية

Team notes

Added: Firth (1957)

CONCEPT

Collocation التلازم اللفظي

Words that naturally go together: “the company a word keeps” (Firth 1957).

Idiom التعبير الاصطلاحي

A fixed expression whose meaning is **not** the sum of its words: *a piece of cake* = “very easy”.

Phraseology التعابير المسكوكة

The fixed and semi-fixed word groups of a language, including collocations, idioms and proverbs.

Collocations

EN → AR

pay money	يدفع مالاً
pay attention	ينتبه / يعير انتباهه
pay a visit	يقوم بزيارة
strong tea	شاي ثقيل
a fast colour	لون ثابت
a close friend	صديق مقرب

Collocations

AR → EN

استل سيفه	drew his sword
يساورني القلق	I am growing worried
لاذ بالفرار	fled
قدّم استقالته	handed in his resignation
حديقة غناء	a lush garden
خرق القانون	broke the law

COMMON ERROR

pay a visit → **يدفع زيارة** × and strong tea → **شاي قوي** ×. Translating collocations word by word sounds foreign.

Idioms

EN → AR

It's raining cats and dogs.	تمطر بغزارة
over the moon	يطير من الفرح
spill the beans	أفشى السرّ
I'm all ears.	كلّي آذان صاغية
Break a leg!	بالتوفيق!

Proverbs

AR → EN

كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار	out of the frying pan into the fire
رجع بخفيّ حنين	came back empty-handed
لكلّ مقام مقال	there is a time and place for everything

KEY TAKEAWAY

Never translate an idiom word by word. But check the context first: at a birthday party, *a piece of cake* may really be الكعكة من قطعة.

One word, many partners

The same English adjective needs a different Arabic word each time. Learn words **with their partners**.

fast...		More pairs	
a fast car	سيارة سريعة	weak coffee	قهوة خفيفة
a fast colour	لون ثابت	a rough sea	بحر هائج
a fast friend	صديق وفيّ	a plain shirt	قيص سادة
fast asleep	غارق في النوم	close cooperation	تعاون وثيق

More idioms EN → AR

to pull one's socks up	شمر عن ساعديه	make a bigger effort
Mark my words.	تذكّر كلامي جيداً	a warning
to hit the sack	أوى إلى فراشه	go to bed
to be in the red	يعاني عجزاً مالياً	to owe money
Don't put words in my mouth.	لا تقولني ما لم أقول	complaint
It's a piece of cake.	الأمر سهل جداً	very easy

Same words, deeper meaning

Boys will be boys.	الولد ولد ولو صار قاضي بلد	colloquial proverb
Business is business.	الشغل شغل	colloquial

Verb partners AR → EN

اتخذ قراراً	made / took a decision	ارتكب خطأً	made a mistake
ألقي محاضرةً	gave a lecture	عقد اجتماعاً	held a meeting

KEY TAKEAWAY

Keep a notebook of **word partners** and **idioms** as you read, in both languages. It is the fastest way to sound natural.

PART II · DECISION-MAKING

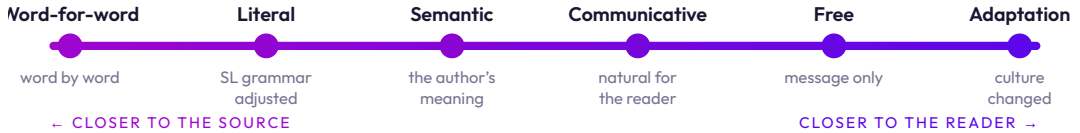
07 Types of translation

أنواع الترجمة

Team notes: literal, free

Added: further types (Newmark 1988)

Some types stay close to the **source text**. Others move closer to the **reader**.



Literal translation

الترجمة الحرفية (المعدلة)

Literal translation keeps the words and adjusts only the grammar. It can be **successful** or **destructive**.

✓ Works: a TL equivalent exists

play a role → يلعب دوراً

The book is on the table. → الكتاب على الطاولة

✗ Fails: no TL equivalent

pay a visit → يقوم بزيارة (use يدفع زيارة)

a long day → يوم شاق (use يوم طويل)

Free translation

الترجمة الحرة

Free translation keeps the message but not the form. Some specialists say a very free version is a **new text**, not a translation.

SOURCE

Appointing new employees should be based on equal opportunity.

TARGET

يجب أن يتم تعيين الموظفين الجدد بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة.

✓ Works: the same message, in words local readers know.

SOURCE

We have had heavy rainfall this winter.

TARGET

سيكون لدينا موسم زراعي مبشّر.

✗ Too free: it adds a conclusion that the source never states.

By medium

Sight translation	Reading a written text aloud in another language
Consecutive / simultaneous	Interpreting after the speaker pauses, or while the speaker talks
Audiovisual	Subtitling and dubbing, with limits on time and space
Localisation · Transcreation	Adapting websites and apps · recreating adverts for a new market

PART II · DECISION-MAKING

08 Translation strategies

استراتيجيات الترجمة

Team notes

Added: superordinate, loan word, compensation, domestication (Baker 2018; Venuti 1995)

CONCEPT

Strategy استراتيجية A planned solution to a translation problem, especially when there is **no direct equivalent**.

Functional translation الترجمة الوظيفية

USE WHEN a TL expression does the same job.

spill the beans → أفشى السرّ

RISK the tone may shift slightly.

Cultural substitution الإبدال الثقافي

USE WHEN a cultural reference would mean nothing to TL readers.

like Romeo and Juliet → كقيسٍ وليلى

RISK you lose the original culture.

ALTERNATIVE add a short explanation.

Addition الإضافة

USE WHEN readers need background. It is common from English into Arabic, a language of elaboration (لغة إسهاب).

the Fed → مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي

RISK never add to titles or headlines.

Omission الحذف

USE WHEN words repeat meaning. It is common from Arabic into English.

شجاعٌ مغوار → *very brave*

RISK never omit real information.

More general word اللفظ الأعمّ

USE WHEN the TL has no specific word.

prawns / shrimps → روبيان

RISK some detail is lost.

Loan word + explanation الاقتراض مع الشرح

USE WHEN a culture-bound term must stay.

الوقف → *waqf* (an Islamic charitable endowment)

RISK too many explanations slow the reader.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Explanatory (descriptive) translation is the **last option**. Use it for cultural and technical words such as الزكاة، العدة. See Ch. 11.

Compensation

التعويض

USE WHEN an effect (a pun, a rhyme, a tone) is lost at one point.

Recreate a similar effect **elsewhere** in the text.

RISK adding effects the author never used.

Domestication · Foreignisation

التوطين · التغريب

Domesticate: make the text feel local. **Foreignise:** keep its foreign flavour (Venuti 1995).

"the diwaniya" (foreignised) · *"a men's evening gathering"* (domesticated)

Translating metaphor

الترجمة المجازية

CONCEPT

Metaphor الاستعارة A comparison **without** "as" or "like": *She is a moon.*

Simile التشبيه A comparison **with** "as" or "like": *She is as beautiful as the moon.*

Go down the ladder and stop at the first step that works.

1

Is the image shared by both languages? Keep it.

She is a snake.

→

إنها أفعى

My paper will see the light next December.

→

سترى ورقتي البحتية النور في ديسمبر المقبل

2

Is it not shared? Use an Arabic image instead.

the tip of the iceberg

→

غيض من فيض

For a positive beginning, use أول الغيث قطرة

3

No image fits? Turn it into a simile.

He is a rock.

→

إنه كالصخرة في ثباته

4

Last resort: give the plain meaning. The image is lost.

He is a chicken.

→

إنه جبان

The decision raised eyebrows.

→

أثار القرار الاستغراب

KEY TAKEAWAY

Keep the image if you can, replace it if you must, and explain it only as a last resort. **Poetry** allows more creative freedom than **prose**.

PART II · DECISION-MAKING

09

The seven translation procedures

إجراءات الترجمة السبعة

Requested in the team notes

Added framework: Vinay & Darbelnet (1958/1995)

A **procedure** (إجراء) is a technique for translating a word, a phrase or a sentence. The seven procedures run from the one **closest to the source** (1) to the **freest** (7).

DIRECT	Borrowing الاقتراض 1	WHAT IT DOES Takes the SL word as it is. WHEN New objects and names	EXAMPLE <i>computer</i> → كمبيوتر <i>ديوانية</i> → diwaniya
	Calque النسخ / المحاكاة 2	WHAT IT DOES Translates each part of an expression literally. WHEN New compound terms	EXAMPLE <i>skyscraper</i> → ناطحة سحاب <i>smartphone</i> → الهاتف الذكي
	Literal الترجمة الحرفية 3	WHAT IT DOES Word for word, and still correct in the TL. WHEN The two structures match	EXAMPLE <i>The book is on the table.</i> → الكتاب على الطاولة
OBLIQUE	Transposition الإبدال 4	WHAT IT DOES Changes the word class: a noun becomes a verb, and so on. WHEN The TL prefers another structure	EXAMPLE <i>after his arrival</i> → بعد أن وصل <i>a heavy smoker</i> → يدخن بشراهة
	Modulation التحوير 5	WHAT IT DOES Changes the point of view, e.g. negative to positive. WHEN The literal version sounds odd	EXAMPLE <i>It is not difficult.</i> → إنه سهل <i>I don't blame you.</i> → معك حق
	Equivalence التكافؤ 6	WHAT IT DOES Describes the same situation with a completely different expression. WHEN Idioms, proverbs, sounds	EXAMPLE <i>Like father, like son.</i> → آخ! → هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد <i>Ouch!</i>
	Adaptation التكيف 7	WHAT IT DOES Replaces a situation unknown in the TL culture with a familiar one. WHEN Cultural references	EXAMPLE <i>like Romeo and Juliet</i> → كتييس ويلي

KEY TAKEAWAY

Start with the **direct** procedures (1–3). Move to the **oblique** ones (4–7) only when the direct result sounds unnatural or unclear.

Procedures in action EN → AR

EXAMPLE

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton and said the reforms were not impossible.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون، وقال إن الإصلاحات ممكنة.

- | | |
|---|--|
| ■ after his arrival → بعد أن وصل | 4 · Transposition: a noun becomes a verb |
| ■ press conference → مؤتمر صحفي | 2 · Calque |
| ■ Sheraton → شيراتون | 1 · Borrowing |
| ■ not impossible → ممكنة | 5 · Modulation: a double negative becomes positive |

Method, strategy or procedure?

Term	What it covers	Example
Type / method	The whole text (Ch. 7)	Translating a news report communicatively
Strategy	A plan for one problem (Ch. 8)	Cultural substitution for an idiom
Procedure	A technique for a word or phrase (Ch. 9)	Transposing a noun into a verb

Quick check: which procedure?

- | | | | |
|---|-------------------------------|---|--|
| 1 | television → تلفزيون | 4 | Keep your chin up. → لا تبتئس |
| 2 | honeymoon → شهر العسل | 5 | It is not unlikely. → من المرجح |
| 3 | before leaving → قبل أن يغادر | 6 | baseball (in a children's story) → كرة القدم |

Answers: 1 borrowing · 2 calque · 3 transposition · 4 equivalence · 5 modulation · 6 adaptation

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

In your commentary (Ch. 15), **name** the procedure and give the reason: “*After his arrival*” was transposed into a verbal clause because Arabic prefers verbs.

PART III · CULTURE, TERMS AND GAPS

10

Cultural approximation

التقريب الثقافي

Team notes

Added: Shakespeare, Sonnet 18 (1609)

CONCEPT

Approximation التقريب

Bringing the SL meaning **as close as possible** to the TL.

Cultural approximation التقريب الثقافي

Doing this for **cultural** meaning. It needs knowledge of both cultures.

Expressions

EN → AR

I've got the test in the bag.

الامتحان في جيبي

cut from the same cloth

من طينة واحدة

like mother, like daughter

أقلب الجيرة على فيها تطلع
البنات لأمها

a scapegoat

كبش الفداء

Titles and institutions

the Home Office (UK)

وزارة الداخلية

Chancellor of the Exchequer (UK)

وزير المالية

Secretary of State (US)

وزير الخارجية

Secretary of the Treasury (US)

وزير الخزانة

When climate changes meaning

SOURCE

The news warmed my heart.

TARGET

أثلج الخبر صدري

Why: in a hot climate, relief feels **cold**. The image is reversed so the feeling stays the same.

EXAMPLE · POETRY

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day? (Shakespeare, Sonnet 18)

In England, summer is mild and lovely. In the Gulf, summer is harsh. Many translators move the image to spring: أشبهك بيوم ربيعي؟

Fixed social expressions

I'm sorry for your loss.

عظم الله أجركم / البقاء لله

condolence

God willing.

إن شاء الله

future plans

Welcome! It's an honour to have you.

أهلاً وسهلاً، شرفتمونا

hospitality

KEY TAKEAWAY

Translate greetings and condolences with the phrase a TL speaker would actually use **in the same situation**, never word by word.

Proverbs with ready equivalents AR → EN

عصفورٌ في اليد خيرٌ من عشرةٍ على الشجرة	<i>A bird in the hand is worth two in the bush.</i>
في التأني السلامة وفي العجلة الندامة	<i>Haste makes waste.</i>
الوقت كالسيف إن لم تقطعه قطعك	<i>Time and tide wait for no man.</i>
هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد	<i>Like father, like son.</i>

Arabic idioms AR → EN

على قدمٍ وساق	<i>in full swing</i>
بين عشيةٍ وضحاها	<i>overnight</i>
رفع الراية البيضاء	<i>raised the white flag (a shared image)</i>

Everyday social expressions AR → EN

الله يعطيك العافية	<i>Thank you for all your hard work.</i>	thanks for effort
تقبل الله	<i>May God accept it.</i>	after prayer or fasting
عساكم من عواده	<i>Many happy returns!</i>	Gulf festive greeting
بخير، الحمد لله	<i>I'm fine, thank you.</i>	reply to "How are you?"

Check the nuance

SOURCE

as busy as a bee

TARGET

يعمل كالنحلة

Careful: the Egyptian expression *زَيَّ آمَّ العروس* means *busy but achieving little*, which is a different meaning. An approximation must match the **nuance**, not just the topic.

Institutions with no match

<i>the House managers</i> (US impeachment trial)	أعضاء مجلس النواب المكلفون بالادعاء
<i>watchdog press · lapdog press</i>	الصحافة الرقابية · الصحافة الموالية للسلطة
<i>a sheriff</i> (US)	مأمور الشرطة في المقاطعة

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Religious expressions carry **register and belief**. *أتَى الله!* can render an angry *What on earth are you saying?*, but only if it suits the speaker and the scene.

PART III · CULTURE, TERMS AND GAPS

11

Descriptive translation

الترجمة الوصفية / الشرحية

Team notes

CONCEPT

Descriptive translation الترجمة الوصفية

Explaining an SL word by **describing its meaning** in the TL. It is also called explanatory translation.

Concept المفهوم

A complex meaning that a single word stands for.

Use it for **cultural, religious and technical** words that have no equivalent. It is the **last option**, because it makes the text longer.

Two steps

1· Transliterate the word

زكاة → *zakat*

2· Describe it briefly

in brackets, or in a footnote

Arabic culture-bound words

AR → EN

الزكاة	<i>zakat</i> : obligatory almsgiving in Islam, paid yearly when certain conditions are met
التيّم	<i>tayammum</i> : ritual washing with clean earth when water is unavailable
البسملة	<i>the basmala</i> : saying "In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful"
العدة	<i>'idda</i> : the waiting period after divorce or the husband's death before a woman may remarry
الصكوك	<i>sukuk</i> : Islamic financial certificates, often called "Islamic bonds"
العتوة	<i>'atwa</i> : a temporary truce under tribal customary law

English culture-bound words

EN → AR

Ali has been sectioned. (UK)

أودع عليٌّ مستشفى للأمراض النفسية بموجب القانون

yin and yang

الين واليانغ (قوتان متضادتان متكاملتان في الفكر الصيني)

COMMON ERROR

Mixing up *psychology* (علم النفس) and *psychiatry* (الطب النفسي). Check what the term means before you explain it.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Transliterate + explain once. After the first mention, the transliterated word alone is enough.

PART III · CULTURE, TERMS AND GAPS

12

Lexical creation

النحت المعجمي / توليد الألفاظ

Team notes

CONCEPT

Lexical creation النحت المعجميCreating a **new word or expression** in the TL for something that has no name there yet (a “lexical gap”).**Lexicalisation** التعجيم

The moment a new word is accepted and enters the dictionary.

Arabicisation التعريب

Adapting a borrowed word to Arabic sounds and word patterns.

Sometimes the translator becomes a **coiner**: someone who makes new words.

Five ways to create a word

Type	How it works	Example
Neologism	A brand-new word	<i>blog</i> → مدوّنة
Calque	Translate each part literally	<i>smartphone</i> → الهاتف الذكي <i>shadow government</i> → حكومة الظل
Transliteration	Borrow the sounds, and add a short definition	<i>radio</i> → راديو
Hybrid	Half translated, half transliterated	<i>cybersecurity</i> → الأمن السيبراني
Explanation	A short descriptive phrase	<i>jet lag</i> → إرهاق السفر

New words in the news

<i>greenwashing</i>	التضليل البيئي	Companies pretending their products are eco-friendly
<i>cancel culture</i>	ثقافة الإلغاء	Publicly dropping support for someone as a punishment
<i>global warming</i>	الاحترار العالمي	An established calque
<i>Valentine's Day</i>	عيد الحبّ	A cultural festival

SOURCE

product cannibalism (marketing)

TARGET

منتج يزاحم منتجاً آخر للشركة نفسها

Why: the literal meaning (eating human flesh) is absurd here. The field of **marketing** tells you the real meaning.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Search before you coin. Check the Arabic language academies, UNTERM and Arabterm (Ch. 13). An accepted term is almost always better than a new invention.

PART III · CULTURE, TERMS AND GAPS

13 Terminology management

إدارة المصطلحات وأدلة المصطلحات

Team notes: terms

Added framework: term records and workflow

CONCEPT

Term المصطلح

A word that names a **concept** in a specialised field. Every field has its own terms.

Terminology guide دليل المصطلحات

A list of the approved terms for a project or client.

Four steps

1 · Extract

find the key terms

2 · Verify

check reliable sources

3 · Record

note term + context

4 · Share

the team uses one list

A model terminology table

Source term	Target term	Domain	Context	Source	Status / notes
<i>governing law</i>	القانون الواجب التطبيق	Legal	Contract clause	Legal dictionary	✓ Preferred Not الحاكم القانون
<i>provided that</i>	شريطة أن	Legal	Conditions	Team notes	✓ Preferred
<i>greenwashing</i>	التضليل البيئي	Environment	News report	Press usage verify	Also seen: الغسل الأخضر
<i>Article (of a law)</i>	مادة	Legal	Constitution	Team notes	<i>clause</i> in a contract = بند
<i>Arabian Gulf</i>	الخليج العربي	Political	Place name	Client style guide	Follow the client and flag it

Four rules

- **Be consistent:** one term for one concept, throughout the text.
- **Record the context,** not just the word.
- **Cite a source** for every term.
- **Mark the status:** preferred, allowed or avoid.

WHERE TO CHECK ARABIC TERMS

UNTERM (United Nations)

Arabterm (technical fields)

The **Arabic language academies** (Cairo, Damascus, Amman)

The client's own glossary and style guide

COMMON ERROR

Changing a term halfway through “for variety”. In specialised texts, a new word suggests a **new concept**.

PART IV · TEXT AND DISCOURSE · STEP 1: ANALYSE

14 Text analysis

تحليل النص قبل الترجمة

Team notes

To analyse a text is to break it down and understand it **before** you translate. A **text** can be anything written: a word, a sentence, a paragraph or a book. Use this page with any unfamiliar text. The grey italic notes show a completed example for a **KUNA news report**.

Author / speaker الكاتب Who wrote or said it? <i>A KUNA correspondent</i>	Publisher الناشر Where was it published? <i>KUNA, the state news agency</i>	Client العميل Who asked for the translation? <i>KUNA's English service</i>
Purpose الغرض Inform, persuade, instruct? <i>To inform</i>	Target audience الجمهور Who will read the TT? <i>Readers interested in Kuwait</i>	Genre الجنس What kind of text is it? <i>A news report</i>
Field المجال What subject area? <i>Politics</i>	Tone النبرة Neutral, critical, warm? <i>Straightforward, neutral</i>	Style الأسلوب Formal or informal? <i>Formal, with no short forms</i>
Context السياق When, where, why? <i>An official visit</i>	Key terms المصطلحات Which words need checking? <i>Ministers' official titles</i>	Cultural elements العناصر الثقافية Anything culture-bound? <i>Forms of address</i>
Potential problems الصعوبات What might go wrong? <i>Connotation, place names</i>	Strategies الاستراتيجيات How will you solve them? <i>Mostly literal (no metaphors)</i>	Resources needed المصادر Which dictionaries and tools? <i>UNTERM, the KUNA archive</i>

ANALYSIS

Shows the text's **features, background and problems**: who, for whom, how and why.

NOT A SUMMARY

A summary only says **what the text is about**. Do not summarise when you are asked to analyse.

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Your analysis and your translation must **agree**. If you call the tone formal, a single casual word in your TT will stand out.

PART IV · TEXT AND DISCOURSE · STEP 3: COMMENT

15

Translation commentary

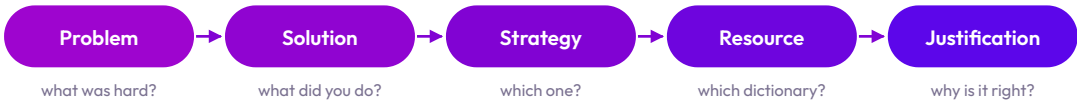
التعليق على الترجمة

Team notes

CONCEPT

Commentary التعليق A short text in which the translator **explains and justifies** the choices made in a translation.

Every translation goes through three steps: **Analysis** → **Translation** → **Commentary**. For each problem in the commentary, follow these five moves:



A model commentary

EXAMPLE

[Problem] The ST says the agreement “remained a dead letter”. [Solution] A literal rendering, حرفاً ميتاً, would confuse Arab readers, so the translator chose حبراً على ورق. [Strategy] This is a functional equivalent. [Resource] Its use was checked in Arabic press texts. [Justification] It is a familiar Arabic idiom and suits the formal news register.

Structure

Part one: reflect on your **analysis** (text type, audience, main problems).

Part two: reflect on your **translation**, one problem at a time.

Rules

- Write in the **third person**: “The translator...”
- **Quote** examples from the ST and TT.
- **Name** the strategy or procedure.
- **Mention** the dictionaries you used.

Useful phrases

The ST features...

To keep..., the translator opted for...

A functional equivalent was preferred because...

This was omitted as it is irrelevant to the target audience.

The term was checked in...

COMMON ERROR

Describing the translation (“I translated the first line...”) without saying **why**. Every comment needs a reason.

TRANSLATOR’S NOTE

Commenting on someone else’s translation? Compare the ST and TT line by line, note what was added, dropped or changed, then judge the result for **accuracy, terms, fluency and fitness for the reader**. Separate real errors from personal taste.

PART IV · TEXT AND DISCOURSE · CHECK

16 Interlingual risk assessment

تقييم المخاطر بين اللغتين

Requested in the team notes

Added framework: risk management (Pym 2015)

CONCEPT

Risk الخطر

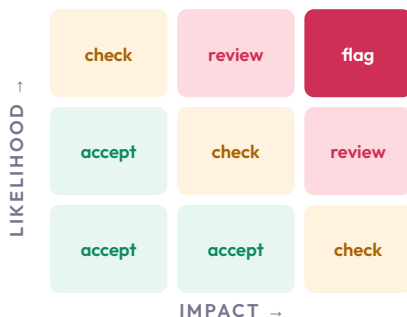
The chance that a translation choice causes a problem for the client, the reader or you.

Mitigation التخفيف

An action that makes the risk smaller.

Before you deliver, go through this matrix. **Impact** asks how bad the problem would be. **Likelihood** asks when it tends to happen.

Risk	Example	Impact	Likelihood	Mitigation
Terminological	<i>governing law</i> → القانون الحاكم	Wrong meaning in a contract	Specialised texts	Specialised dictionary, term list
Semantic	A dropped “not”	The opposite meaning	Long sentences, MT output	Compare segment by segment
Cultural	<i>warmed my heart</i> → أدفأ قلبي	The effect is lost	Idioms, images	Cultural approximation (Ch. 10)
Pragmatic	أشعر بالحرّ as a request	The intention is missed	Dialogue	Ask: what is meant?
Stylistic	A dialect word in a formal report	Looks unprofessional	Informal sources	Re-read against the brief
Ideological	<i>Persian / Arabian Gulf</i>	Offends the client or readers	Politics, news	Client style guide; flag it
Legal	<i>shall</i> → سوف	The obligation disappears	Contracts	Use the Arabic present tense
Technical	Wrong units or numbers	Harm or damage	Manuals, medicine	Check every figure
Ambiguity	علم = flag, knowledge or taught?	A wrong reading	Arabic without diacritics	Read the co-text



PLOT YOUR OWN RISKS

Place each risky item from your translation in the grid. **Accept** low risks, **check** medium ones against a source, get a second person to **review** high ones, and **flag** critical ones to the client.

The grid is a thinking tool, not a measurement. How high a risk is depends on the text and the client.

PART IV · TEXT AND DISCOURSE · ANALYSE DEEPER

17

Fairclough's relational model

نموذج فيركلف العلائقي في التحليل النقدي للخطاب

Requested in the team notes

Added framework: Fairclough (1992, 2009)

CONCEPT

Discourse الخطاب

Language in use, in real social situations.

Critical discourse analysis التحليل النقدي للخطاب

Studying how language shows, supports or challenges **power and ideology**.

Ideology الأيديولوجيا

A set of beliefs that shapes how events are described.

3 · SOCIAL PRACTICE

2 · DISCOURSE PRACTICE

1 · TEXT

describe the words

interpret: who produced it, for whom

explain: power, ideology, society

Fairclough looks at every text on **three levels**, one inside the other. He calls the approach *relational* because the text, its production and society all shape one another.

Why translators care: a translation is also discourse. Your word choices can **keep, soften or strengthen** the stance of the ST.

Loaded choices

EN → AR

regime · government

نظام · حكومة "Regime" takes away legitimacy

militants · terrorists · fighters

مسلّحون · إرهابيون · مقاتلون Each one takes a side

Protesters were killed.

قُتل متظاهرون The passive hides who did it

□ FAIRCLOUGH CHECKLIST

□ **Text:** which words carry judgement?

□ **Society:** whose interests does it serve?

□ **Text:** who is the doer, and is the doer hidden?

□ **Your TT:** did you keep, soften or strengthen the stance?

□ **Discourse:** who produced it, and for which outlet?

□ **Your TT:** did you flag loaded terms?

KEY TAKEAWAY

No word choice is neutral. When the ST takes a stance, **notice it, follow the client's policy, and explain your choice** in the commentary.

PART V · PROFESSIONAL PRACTICE

18 Genre-based translation

الترجمة حسب الجنس النصي

Requested in the team notes

Examples written for this handbook, except the poetry line

A **genre** (الجنس النصي) is a familiar type of text. Each genre has its own rules, so identify the genre **first** (Ch. 14).

Genre	What matters	Example	Mini task
News الخبر	Facts first, neutral tone, short headlines	<i>Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.</i> ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.	Write an Arabic headline: <i>Kuwait, Australia sign trade deal</i>
Political السياسي	Loaded words, set diplomatic phrases	<i>The two sides held frank and constructive talks.</i> أجرى الجانبان محادثاتٍ صريحةً وبناءةً.	Compare <i>regime</i> and <i>government</i> (Ch. 17)
Legal القانوني	Precision, fixed formulas; <i>shall</i> = obligation	<i>This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.</i> تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.	Translate <i>provided that</i> in a sentence
Institutional الرسمي	Official names and titles, formal register	<i>The Ministry of Foreign Affairs announced...</i> أعلنت وزارة الخارجية...	Translate <i>Chancellor of the Exchequer</i>
Medical الطبي	Zero ambiguity, exact doses	<i>Take one tablet twice daily after meals.</i> تناول قرصاً واحداً مرتين يومياً بعد الأكل.	Explain <i>psychology</i> vs <i>psychiatry</i>
Technical التقني	Clear commands, consistent terms	<i>Press and hold the power button for five seconds.</i> اضغط مطوّلاً على زرّ التشغيل لمدة خمس ثوانٍ.	Find the Arabic for <i>cybersecurity</i>
Academic الأكاديمي	Careful claims, formal style	<i>The results suggest that...</i> تشير النتائج إلى أن...	Translate <i>This study examines...</i>
Literary الأدبي	Voice, feeling, natural dialogue	<i>It has been a long day.</i> طويلاً (not) كان يوماً شاقاً.	Translate <i>He was over the moon.</i>
Poetry الشعر	Image, rhythm, beauty; more freedom	الخيّلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني <i>The horses, the night and the desert know me</i> (al-Mutanabbi)	Keep the rhythm of the list
Advertising الإعلاني	Persuasion, rhythm, wordplay	<i>Save more. Smile more.</i> وفر أكثر... وابتسم أكثر!	Keep the parallel structure

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

News is excellent practice material: it covers every topic and is always up to date. In workshops, bring a **current news article** and translate it with the text-analysis page (Ch. 14).

PART V · PROFESSIONAL PRACTICE

19 Dictionaries, resources and AI/MT

المعاجم المطبوعة والرقمية والترجمة الآلية

Requested in the team notes Added framework: resource guide and MT basics

CONCEPT

- Bilingual dictionary** معجم ثنائي اللغة Gives equivalents. Use it to **find** options.
- Monolingual dictionary** معجم أحادي اللغة Explains words in one language. Use it to **confirm** the meaning.

What to look for in a dictionary entry

Definitions Which sense fits?	Collocations Which words go with it?	Register Formal or informal?	Domain Legal, medical...?
Usage notes Warnings, limits	Examples Real sentences	Reliability Who made it?	Date Is it current?

Resource	Best for
Al-Mawrid (English–Arabic, Arabic–English)	Everyday vocabulary in both directions
Hans Wehr, <i>A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic</i>	Arabic words organised by root
Al-Mu‘jam al-Wasīṭ المعجم الوسيط	Confirming Arabic meanings
Oxford Collocations Dictionary	Finding natural English word partners
Online dictionaries (e.g. Almaany)	Quick look-ups. Always double-check them.
UNTERM · Arabterm	Official and technical terms

The three-check rule: find options in a **bilingual** dictionary → confirm in a **monolingual** one → see real use in a parallel text.

The three-check rule in action

EXAMPLE

1 · Bilingual	<i>fast colour</i> : the options include سريع، صائم، ثابت
2 · Monolingual	ثابت = “does not fade”, which fits colours
3 · Parallel text	ألوان ثابتة appears in Arabic textile texts
Decision	✓ لون ثابت

COMMON ERROR

Taking the **first** meaning a bilingual dictionary gives. It is often not the right one for your context.

Machine translation and AI

الترجمة الآلية والذكاء الاصطناعي

CONCEPT

Machine translation الترجمة الآلية Translation done by software, such as neural MT or AI chat tools (LLMs).

Hallucination الهلوسة AI output that sounds right but is **not in the source**, such as an added fact or a lost “not”.

WHEN TO USE MACHINE TRANSLATION

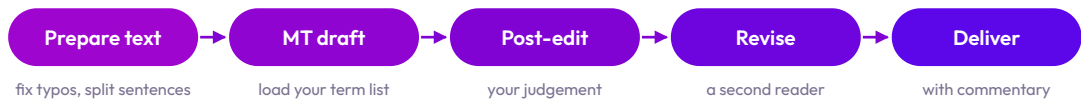
✓ Useful for

A first draft of simple texts · checking ideas · large volumes

✗ Risky for

Legal, medical and religious texts · idioms and poetry · confidential files

A safe workflow



Typical machine errors EN → AR

Error	Machine output	Correction
Literal idiom	<i>raining cats and dogs</i> → تمطر قططاً وكلاباً ✗	تمطر بغزارة
Wrong gender	<i>The doctor said she...</i> → قال الطبيب ✗	قالت الطبيبة
English word order	الحكومة أعلنت... ✗	أعلنت الحكومة...
Wrong collocation	<i>pay attention</i> → ادفع الانتباه ✗	انتبه

Five rules for responsible use

- 1 **You are responsible** for every word you deliver, whatever tool you used.
- 2 **Protect the client.** Never paste private or confidential text into a public AI tool.
- 3 **Verify terms, names, numbers, dates and every “not”.**
- 4 **Check culture and context.** MT often translates idioms word by word.
- 5 **Be open.** Tell the client if you used MT or AI.

EXAMPLE · A CLEAR AI INSTRUCTION

Translate the text below from English into Modern Standard Arabic for readers in the Gulf. Use a formal news style and verb-first sentences. Use this term: greenwashing = التصليل البيئي. Do not add, omit or summarise anything. List any unclear phrases separately.

PART V · PROFESSIONAL PRACTICE

20

Translation quality and post-editing

جودة الترجمة والتحرير اللاحق

Team notes: revision and post-editing

Added framework: ISO 18587 (2017)

CONCEPT

Revision المراجعة

Checking a translation against the source and correcting it.

Post-editing التحرير اللاحق

A human correcting machine translation. The team notes call it the **new direction** for translators.

Light post-editing

The text is **correct and understandable**, but not polished. It is for internal use.

Full post-editing

The text is **ready to publish**, as good as a human translation.

Six quality criteria

Criterion	Ask yourself
Accuracy	Is the meaning the same? Was anything added or lost?
Fluency	Does it read as if it had been written in the TL?
Terminology	Are the terms correct and consistent with the term list?
Grammar	Are agreement, tense, spelling and hamza all correct?
Style	Do the register and tone fit the brief?
Formatting	Are numbers, names, titles, captions and punctuation all correct?

Revise in three readings

- 1 **Accuracy reading**, with the ST next to you: check meaning, omissions and additions.
- 2 **Fluency reading**, without the ST: does it sound natural?
- 3 **Final proofread**: numbers, names, punctuation, titles and captions.

A full list of common grammar and style mistakes is on the next page.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Judge every translation for **accuracy, fluency, terminology, grammar, style and formatting**, and check every **number, name, title and caption**. The full checklist is on p. 38.

Common grammar and style mistakes

أخطاء شائعة

These mistakes appear in every kind of text. Check for them every time you revise.

IN ARABIC TRANSLATIONS EN → AR

Mistake	✗	✓
Subject first by habit	الحكومة أعلنت...	أعلنت الحكومة...
Overusing قام بـ	قام الوزير بزيارة الكويت	زار الوزير الكويت
Passive with من قِبَل	تم افتتاح المعرض من قِبَل الوزير	افتتح الوزير المعرض
Numbers 3–10	ثلاث طلاب	ثلاثة طلاب
Accusative after أصبح / كان	أصبح الجو بارد	أصبح الجو بارداً
Hamza, هـ / ي / ة	إنشاء · مدرسه · الى	إنشاء · مدرسة · إلى
Pronoun agreement	المدينة وسكانه	المدينة وسكانها
Letter openings	حضرة السيد عزيزي السيد أحمد (formal letter)	حضرة السيد أحمد المحترم

IN ENGLISH TRANSLATIONS AR → EN

Mistake	✗	✓
Long sentences joined by <i>and</i>	...and he said, and he added, and...	Split them with full stops.
Kept synonym pairs	<i>brave and daring</i>	<i>very brave</i>
Generic <i>the</i>	<i>The life is beautiful.</i>	<i>Life is beautiful.</i>
Missing <i>to be</i>	<i>He in the office.</i>	<i>He is in the office.</i>
Preposition copied from Arabic	<i>He married from her.</i> (تزوج منها)	<i>He married her.</i>
Past for present perfect	<i>I lived here since 2010.</i>	<i>I have lived here since 2010.</i>
No capitals in titles	<i>the minister of health</i>	<i>the Minister of Health</i>
Mixed spellings of names	<i>Mohammed / Muhammad</i>	Choose one and keep it.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Read your translation **once without the source**. If a sentence sounds translated, it needs rewriting.

● ● ● PART VI • PRACTICE LAB

1

Level 1 • Foundation

المستوى الأول: الأساسيات

Examples from the team notes

Sentences. Translate each one, then name the concept or strategy you used. The chip on the right tells you which chapter to look at. Answer guidance starts on p. 36.

English → Arabic

- | | | |
|---|---|----------------------|
| 1 | <i>She paid a visit to her grandmother.</i> | Collocation • Ch. 6 |
| 2 | <i>The agreement has remained a dead letter.</i> | Equivalence • Ch. 5 |
| 3 | <i>He is a heavy smoker.</i> | Procedure • Ch. 9 |
| 4 | <i>It's raining cats and dogs.</i> | Idiom • Ch. 6 |
| 5 | <i>The Home Office issued a statement.</i> | Culture • Ch. 10 |
| 6 | <i>This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.</i> | Legal genre • Ch. 18 |

Arabic → English

- | | | |
|----|--------------------------------------|----------------------|
| 7 | رجع بخفي حنين. | Proverb • Ch. 6 |
| 8 | أُتلج الخبر صدري. | Culture • Ch. 10 |
| 9 | هو شجاع مغوار. | Omission • Ch. 8 |
| 10 | يساورني القلق بشأن النتائج. | Collocation • Ch. 6 |
| 11 | تُعدّ الزكاة ركناً من أركان الإسلام. | Descriptive • Ch. 11 |
| 12 | قدّم الوزير استقالته أمس. | Word order • Ch. 3 |

TIP

Before you write, ask: **is this a collocation, an idiom or a cultural item?** The answer tells you which strategy to use.

Level 1 • Spot and fix the error

اكتشف الخطأ وصحّحه

Each translation below contains **one mistake**. Find it, correct it, and name the problem. Answers are on p. 36.

#	Source	Translation with a mistake
1	<i>Pay attention, please.</i>	ادفع الانتباه من فضلك.
2	<i>The government announced new measures.</i>	الحكومة أعلنت إجراءاتٍ جديدة.
3	<i>I have three brothers.</i>	لديّ ثلاث إخوة.
4	<i>Is the meeting today?</i>	هل الاجتماع اليوم؟
5	<i>It has been a long day.</i>	لقد كان يوماً طويلاً.
6	<i>She drinks strong tea.</i>	تشرب شايًا قوياً.
7	هو شجاعٌ مغوار.	<i>He is brave and daring.</i>
8	الحياة جميلة.	<i>The life is beautiful.</i>
9	تزوج منها العام الماضي.	<i>He married from her last year.</i>
10	رجع بخفي حنين.	<i>He returned with Hunayn's shoes.</i>

Match the idiom

صل التعبير بمقابله

A <i>to spill the beans</i>	1 كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار
B <i>over the moon</i>	2 كبش الفداء
C <i>I'm all ears.</i>	3 أفشى السرّ
D <i>out of the frying pan into the fire</i>	4 كلّ آذانٍ صاغية
E <i>a scapegoat</i>	5 يطير من الفرّح

Answers: A-3 • B-5 • C-4 • D-1 • E-2

TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

Finding mistakes in other people's work is excellent training for **revising your own**. Use the checklists on p. 38.

2

Level 2 · Applied

المستوى الثاني: التطبيق

Short texts. For each text: (1) fill in the brief (client, purpose, audience), (2) translate it, and (3) write two commentary sentences (Ch. 15).

2a · Human rights text

EN → AR

All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.

Authentic text: United Nations (1948), *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*, Article 1.

Focus: passive *are born* · the formal register · compare your version with the official UN Arabic text.

2b · Classical poetry

AR → EN

الخيْلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني · والسيفُ والرمحُ والقرطاسُ والقلمُ

Authentic text: al-Mutanabbi (d. 965 CE), *Diwān*.

Focus: keep the rhythm of the list · choose a register for القُرطاس · poetry allows more freedom (Ch. 8).

2c · English poetry

EN → AR

*Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more temperate.*

Authentic text: William Shakespeare, Sonnet 18 (1609), lines 1–2.

Focus: summer or spring? Justify your choice with cultural approximation (Ch. 10).

2d · News paragraph

EN → AR

The city's central library will extend its opening hours during the summer holiday, officials announced on Sunday. The library will stay open until 10 p.m. on weekdays, and free workshops on creative writing and translation will also be held.

► Practice text written for this handbook in news style. In workshops, use a current authentic news article as well.

Focus: put the verb first · where does *officials announced* go? · *stay open*.

3

Level 3 · Professional

المستوى الثالث: الاحتراف

Full texts. Work through the full cycle, exactly as a professional would.

- 1 **Analyse** the text with the framework on p. 23.
- 2 **Translate**, choosing a strategy for every problem (Ch. 5–13).
- 3 **Revise** with the checklists on p. 38.
- 4 Write a **150-word commentary** (Ch. 15).
- 5 Place **three risks** in the risk grid (Ch. 16), and run the **Fairclough checklist** (Ch. 17).

3a · News feature

EN → AR

Health officials have urged residents to stay indoors between 11 a.m. and 4 p.m. as temperatures are expected to top 50°C this week. “Heatstroke is not something to take lightly,” a Ministry of Health spokesperson said, advising people to drink plenty of water and to check on elderly neighbours. Outdoor workers are most at risk. Meanwhile, shopping malls are expected to be packed as families seek relief from the heat.

Practice text written for this handbook in news style.

Watch for: top 50°C · not something to take lightly (modulation) · check on · packed · numbers and times.

3b · Cultural news

AR → EN

احتفلت الجمعية الثقافية مساءً أمس بتكريم نخبةٍ من المترجمين الشباب، وذلك في أمسيةٍ حضرها لفيفٌ من الأدباء والأكاديميين. وأكّد رئيس الجمعية في كلمته أنّ الترجمة جسّر يصل الشعوب بعضها ببعض، مشيراً إلى أنّ العناية بالمترجمين الشباب واجبٌ لا ترف. واختُتِمت الأمسية بقراءاتٍ شعريةٍ مترجمة، وسط أجواءٍ سادها الودّ والتقدير.

Practice text written for this handbook in news style.

Watch for: one long sentence joined by و · the collocation من لفيف · the metaphor جسّر · the synonym pair الودّ والتقدير.

● ● ● PRACTICE LAB

Answer guidance

إرشادات الإجابة

Translation often has **more than one good answer**. These are suggestions, not the only correct versions. Any rendering that is accurate, natural and fits the brief is acceptable.

Level 1

#	Suggested translation	Strategy	Why	Alternative
1	زارت جدتها.	Collocation	"Pay a visit" is just "visit", not دفع	قامت بزيارة جدتها
2	ظلت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.	Functional equivalence	An Arabic idiom does the same job	لم تُطبق الاتفاقية
3	يدخن بشراهة.	Transposition	Adjective + noun become verb + adverbial	مدخن شره
4	تمطر بغزارة.	Idiom → plain meaning	The English image means nothing in Arabic	تمطر كأفواه القرب
5	أصدرت وزارة الداخلية البريطانية بياناً.	Cultural approximation	"Home Office" is the interior ministry; the verb comes first	—
6	تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.	Legal convention	Legal <i>shall</i> becomes the Arabic present tense, not سوف	—
7	<i>He came back empty-handed.</i>	Equivalence	A proverb is matched to its meaning	<i>He returned with nothing.</i>
8	<i>The news warmed my heart.</i>	Cultural approximation	Arabic "cold" relief becomes English "warmth"	<i>...delighted me</i>
9	<i>He is very brave.</i>	Omission	English does not need two synonyms	<i>He is fearless.</i>
10	<i>I am growing worried about the results.</i>	Collocation	Natural English for يساورني	<i>I am concerned about...</i>
11	<i>Zakat, obligatory almsgiving, is one of the pillars of Islam.</i>	Borrowing + description	Explain the term the first time it appears	—
12	<i>The minister resigned yesterday.</i>	Word order + collocation	Subject first; قدم استقالته = "resigned"	<i>...handed in his resignation</i>

Spot and fix the error (p. 33)

1	انتبه من فضلك.	Collocation	6	نشرب شايًا ثقيلاً.	Collocation
2	أعلنت الحكومة إجراءات جديدة.	Word order	7	<i>He is very brave.</i>	Omission
3	لدي ثلاثة إخوة.	Number agreement	8	<i>Life is beautiful.</i>	Generic the
4	هل الاجتماع اليوم؟	Punctuation	9	<i>He married her last year.</i>	Preposition
5	لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.	Literal translation	10	<i>He came back empty-handed.</i>	Proverb

Level 2

2A · SUGGESTED

يُولدُ جميعُ الناسِ أحراراً ومتساوين في الكرامة والحقوق،
وقد وهبوا العقل والضمير، وعليهم أن يعامل بعضهم
بعضاً بروح الإخاء.

WHY

Verb first (يُولد). The two sentences are joined with *و*. *Endowed* becomes *وهبوا*. **Alternative:** *الوجدان* for *conscience*. Always compare with the official UN Arabic text.

2B · SUGGESTED

*The horses, the night and the desert know me,
as do the sword, the spear, the paper and the
pen.*

WHY

The list of seven nouns is kept, with no added words. *القرطاس* becomes *paper*. **Alternative:** *steed* and *parchment*, for a more classical tone.

2C · SUGGESTED

أَشْبَهَكَ يَوْمٌ مِنْ أَيَّامِ الرَّبِيعِ؟ أَنْتِ أَبْهَى مِنْهُ وَأَكْثَرُ
اعْتِدَالاً.

WHY

Cultural approximation: a Gulf reader feels a summer's day as harsh, but spring as mild and lovely. **Alternative:** keep *الصيف* and add a footnote.

2D · SUGGESTED

أعلن مسؤولون يوم الأحد أنَّ المكتبة المركزية في المدينة
ستمدد ساعات عملها خلال العطلة الصيفية، إذ ستُظل
مفتوحة حتى العاشرة مساءً في أيام العمل، كما ستُعقد
ورش عمل مجانية في الكتابة الإبداعية والترجمة.

WHY

The reporting clause moves to the front, as Arabic news does. *Stay open* becomes *تظل*. The sentences are joined with *و* and *كما*.

Quick check (p. 17)

1 borrowing · 2 calque · 3 transposition · 4 equivalence · 5 modulation · 6 adaptation

Level 3 · guidance points

3a

- *top 50°C* → تجاوز 50 درجة مئوية
- *not something to take lightly* → ضربة
- (modulation) الشمس أمرٌ خطير
- *check on* → الاطمئنان على
- *packed* → مكتظة

3b · Suggested opening

Last night, the Cultural Society honoured a group of outstanding young translators at an evening attended by writers and academics.

- Split the long sentence
- Keep the *bridge* metaphor: the image is shared
- *الودّ والتقدير* → *a warm, appreciative atmosphere*

FOR WORKSHOP LEADERS

Compare students' **commentaries**, not just their translations. The strongest translators can explain their choices.

● ● ● QUICK REFERENCE · KEEP THIS PAGE OPEN

Checklists

قوائم التحقق

☐ BEFORE TRANSLATION

- ☐ Identify the **client**
- ☐ Identify the **purpose**
- ☐ Identify the **audience**
- ☐ Identify the **genre**
- ☐ Identify the **tone**
- ☐ Mark the **terminology**
- ☐ Mark **cultural issues**
- ☐ Gather your **resources**

☐ DURING TRANSLATION

- ☐ **Meaning** preserved
- ☐ **Terms** consistent
- ☐ **Register** right for the brief
- ☐ **Collocations** natural
- ☐ **Cultural references** handled
- ☐ **Strategy** suits each problem

☐ AFTER TRANSLATION

- ☐ **Accuracy**: nothing added or lost
- ☐ **Fluency**: reads naturally
- ☐ **Terminology**
- ☐ **Grammar** and spelling
- ☐ **Style** and punctuation
- ☐ **Formatting**
- ☐ **Numbers and names**
- ☐ **Titles and captions**
- ☐ **Sources** verified

☐ ANALYSIS (CH. 14)

- ☐ Author, publisher and client noted
- ☐ Purpose, audience and genre named
- ☐ Field, tone and style described
- ☐ Key terms and cultural items listed
- ☐ Problems, strategies and resources planned
- ☐ An analysis, **not** a summary

☐ COMMENTARY (CH. 15)

- ☐ Problem → solution → strategy → resource → justification
- ☐ Examples quoted from the ST and TT
- ☐ Written in the third person
- ☐ Dictionaries and sources named
- ☐ Analysis and translation agree

☐ DISCOURSE (CH. 17)

- ☐ Loaded words noticed
- ☐ Hidden doers (passive) noticed
- ☐ Client policy followed
- ☐ Choices explained in the commentary

RISK GRID (CH. 16)

LIKELIHOOD	check	review	flag
	accept	check	review
	accept	accept	check
IMPACT			

THE FULL CYCLE



WORKSHEET · PHOTOCOPY FOR WORKSHOPS

Text analysis worksheet

ورقة عمل: تحليل النص

Text title: _____ Direction: ☐ EN → AR ☐ AR → EN Date: _____

Author / speaker الكاتب _____ _____	Publisher الناشر _____ _____	Client العميل _____ _____
Purpose الغرض _____ _____	Target audience الجمهور _____ _____	Genre الجنس _____ _____
Field المجال _____ _____	Tone النبرة _____ _____	Style الأسلوب _____ _____
Context السياق _____ _____	Key terms المصطلحات _____ _____	Cultural elements العناصر الثقافية _____ _____
Potential problems الصعوبات _____ _____	Strategies الاستراتيجيات _____ _____	Resources needed المصادر _____ _____

MY MENTAL DRAFT: FIRST IDEAS FOR THE HARDEST SENTENCE

Terminology worksheet

جدول المصطلحات

Source term	Target term	Domain	Context	Source	Status / notes

Commentary worksheet

التعليق على الترجمة

Use one card for each translation problem (Ch. 15). Write in the third person: “The translator...”

Problem

.....

.....

Solution

.....

.....

Strategy / procedure

.....

.....

Resource

.....

.....

Justification

.....

.....

● ● ● QUICK REFERENCE

Glossary

مسرد المصطلحات

Key terms, their Arabic equivalents, short definitions and the page where each is explained.

Adaptation	التكيف	16	Cultural approximation	التقريب الثقافي	18
Replacing a situation unknown in the TL culture with a familiar one			Approximating cultural meaning		
Addition	الإضافة	14	Cultural substitution	الإبدال الثقافي	14
Adding words the TL reader needs			Replacing a cultural item with a TL one		
Approximation	التقريب	18	Denotation	المعنى المعجمي	8
Bringing SL meaning as close as possible to the TL			The basic dictionary meaning		
Arabicisation	التعريب	21	Descriptive translation	الترجمة الوصفية	20
Fitting a borrowed word to Arabic sounds and patterns			Explaining a word by describing its meaning		
Bilingual dictionary	معجم ثنائي اللغة	28	Discourse	الخطاب	26
Gives equivalents in another language			Language in use in society		
Borrowing	الاقتراض	16	Domestication	التوطين	15
Taking an SL word as it is			Making a text feel local to TL readers		
Calque	النسخ	16	Equivalence	التكافؤ	10
Translating each part of an expression literally			Finding the TL expression that matches the SL one		
Collocation	التلازم اللفظي	11	Foreignisation	التعريب	15
Words that naturally go together			Keeping the foreign flavour of a text		
Commentary	التعليق على الترجمة	24	Form	البناء	8
A text that explains and justifies translation choices			The structure of words and sentences		
Commissioned translator	مترجم بتكليف	4	Formal equivalence	التكافؤ الشكلي	10
Works for a client (a freelancer included)			Keeps the SL form		
Communication	التواصل	4	Free translation	الترجمة الحرة	13
Understanding and being understood			Keeps the message, not the form		
Communicative translation	الترجمة التواصلية	13	Functional equivalence	التكافؤ الوظيفي	10
Natural translation focused on the reader			Keeps the function with a TL expression		
Compensation	التعويض	15	Genre	الجنس النصي	27
Recreating a lost effect elsewhere in the text			A familiar type of text, such as news or a contract		
Concept	المفهوم	20	Hallucination	الهلوسة	28
A complex meaning that a word stands for			AI output that is not in the source		
Connotation	المعنى الإيحائي	8	Homonymy	المشترك اللفظي	9
The extra feeling a word carries			One word with unrelated meanings		
Context	السياق	8	Hybrid	المصطلح المجين	21
Background that helps us understand a text			A term that is half translated, half transliterated		
Critical discourse analysis	التحليل النقدي للخطاب	26	Ideational equivalence	التكافؤ الفكري	10
Studying power and ideology in language			Keeps only the basic idea		
			Ideology	الأيديولوجيا	26
			Beliefs that shape how events are described		

Idiom	التعبير الاصطلاحي	11
A fixed phrase whose meaning is not the sum of its words		
Interpretation	الترجمة الشفهية	4
Oral translation of speech		
Lexical creation	النحت المعجمي	21
Creating a new word for a lexical gap		
Lexicalisation	التعجيم	21
When a new word enters the dictionary		
Linking words	أدوات الربط	7
Words that join ideas, e.g. however, therefore		
Literal translation	الترجمة الحرفية	13
Keeps the words and adjusts the grammar		
Loan word + explanation	الاقتراض مع الشرح	14
Keeping a term and explaining it		
Localisation	الأقلمة	13
Adapting websites and apps for a market		
Machine translation	الترجمة الآلية	28
Translation done by software		
Meaning	المعنى	8
The idea that words express		
Metaphor	الاستعارة	15
A comparison without “as” or “like”		
Mitigation	التخفيف	25
An action that reduces a risk		
Modulation	التحوير	16
Changing the point of view		
Monolingual dictionary	معجم أحادي اللغة	28
Explains words in one language		
More general word	اللفظ الأعم	14
A broader word when no exact one exists		
Neologism	اللفظ المستحدث	21
A brand-new word		
Omission	الحذف	14
Removing words that repeat meaning		
Phraseology	التعابير المسكوكة	11
The fixed word groups of a language		
Polysemy	تعدد المعنى	9
One word with related meanings		
Post-editing	التحرير اللاحق	30
A human correcting machine output		
Procedure	الإجراء	16
A technique for a word or phrase		

Proverb	المثل	11
A traditional saying		
Register	المستوى اللغوي	6
How formal the language is		
Revision	المراجعة	30
Checking a translation against the source		
Risk	الخطر	25
The chance that a choice causes a problem		
Self-initiated translator	مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية	4
Chooses the text, with no client		
Semantic translation	الترجمة الدلالية	13
Stays close to the author’s meaning		
Sight translation	الترجمة المنظورة	13
Reading a text aloud in another language		
Simile	التشبيه	15
A comparison with “as” or “like”		
Speaker meaning	قصد المتكلم	8
What a speaker really means		
Strategy	الاستراتيجية	14
A planned solution to a problem		
Term	المصطلح	22
A word naming a concept in a field		
Terminology guide	دليل المصطلحات	22
The list of approved terms		
Text	النص	23
Any piece of language that communicates		
Text analysis	تحليل النص	23
Breaking a text down before translating		
Transcreation	الترجمة الإبداعية	13
Recreating an advert for a new market		
Translation	الترجمة التحريرية	4
Transferring written meaning between languages		
Translation brief	موجز الترجمة	5
Client + purpose + audience		
Transliteration	النقل الصوتي	21
Writing SL sounds in TL letters		
Transposition	الإبدال	16
Changing the word class		
Verbal sentence	الجملة الفعلية	6
A sentence that starts with a verb		

● ● ● QUICK REFERENCE

References and editorial notes

المراجع وملاحظات التحرير

SOURCES NAMED IN THE TEAM MATERIALS

Course materials: the “180” textbook and the “182” course book used by the Translation Team. ► **Full author, title and year to be added**

الترجمة: ماهيتها, a text cited in the team notes. ► **Author and publication details to be confirmed**

KUNA (Kuwait News Agency): the worked news-analysis example (Ch. 2, 14).

SOURCES FOR MATERIAL ADDED TO COMPLETE THE FRAMEWORK

Baker, M. (2018). *In Other Words: A Coursebook on Translation* (3rd ed.). Routledge.

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EDITORIAL NOTES · TO SETTLE BEFORE THE FINAL PRINT RUN

1. Add full details for the 180 and 182 course books, and for **الترجمة: ماهيتها**. Mark any passages taken from that text.
2. The notes ask for a checklist based on **Dr Abdullah's framework**. It will be added once the framework is supplied.
3. Replace the practice texts marked ► **verify** with authentic news articles, used with permission.

Coming in future editions: a full **Arabic-language edition**, more practice texts from the news, expanded terminology guides, dictionary examples, and specialised modules (legal, medical, audiovisual).

“Behind every form there is a meaning. You may change the form, but never the meaning.”

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